DIGITAL TRUST FUTURES
FOUNDATION

DTFF PERSPECTIVE

Making Digital Identity Work Across Borders

What has to be agreed before one country can rely on another's credentials

Why this matters now

Cross-border digital identity should make it easier for people to access services and demonstrate legitimate credentials without repeatedly surrendering personal information. Its success depends on whether an institution in one country can lawfully and confidently rely on evidence issued in another. Connecting databases is only part of the task. Governments must also agree what a credential proves, who may use it, who answers for mistakes, and how people recover when verification fails.

Prepared by Godfrey Kutumela, Digital Trust Futures Foundation

October 2026 | Classification: Public

For Africa, this is an opportunity to improve access for migrants, traders and mobile workers while strengthening institutional accountability. The practical starting point is a limited set of useful services, supported by clear rules and independent assurance. A system should earn wider acceptance through evidence of security, inclusion and operational reliability.

Trust must travel with the credential

Interoperability has legal, regulatory, organisational, technical and operational dimensions. A working interface does not establish permission to share data or rely on a foreign identity. Compatible formats do not guarantee equivalent enrolment checks, authentication strength or institutional oversight. Participants need a common understanding of assurance, supported by evidence about how credentials are issued, protected, updated and revoked.

Identification, authentication and authorisation must also remain distinct. Establishing identity does not establish permission to enter a country, practise a profession or receive a particular service. Likewise, a verified identity is only one part of financial due diligence. It does not automatically establish beneficial ownership, source of funds or other information a regulated institution must assess. Each service should specify the attributes it needs and the decisions that remain its responsibility.

Build around useful services

Travel documents, health credentials, financial onboarding and professional qualifications illustrate different reasons to recognise identity across borders. Their requirements should not be forced into one model. A border authority needs different evidence from a remittance provider or an employer checking a qualification. More sensitive uses, including policing and personnel vetting, require particularly strong legal justification, accuracy controls, and due process.

Passports, national identity systems, wallets and visas should evolve coherently while retaining distinct functions. A passport supports evidence of nationality and identity for travel; a visa records permission granted by the destination. A wallet can carry credentials issued by different authorities, but cannot make them legally interchangeable. The goal should be compatible trust mechanisms and clearly assigned authority, with separate permissions and data use for each service.

A focused corridor between willing countries can test these arrangements before wider expansion. The pilot should address a genuine user problem, involve institutions authorised to act, and measure improvements against existing practice. Bilateral implementation can generate lessons for a broader trust framework, while legal recognition and liability arrangements must be settled before live reliance begins. Regional agreements can then extend proven arrangements rather than attempt to resolve every use case at once.

Secure the whole chain of reliance

Cross-border verification inherits risks from issuers, intermediaries, devices and relying institutions. A compromised signing key, fraudulent enrolment or poorly controlled broker can undermine confidence beyond the original organisation. Participants therefore need a minimum security baseline, independent

assessment, incident notification and the ability to suspend unsafe connections. Assurance must cover the complete service, including suppliers and operational dependencies.

Federated verification and user-held credentials can reduce unnecessary centralisation, but neither guarantees privacy or resilience. A broker may accumulate revealing authentication metadata, while a wallet may be vulnerable through the user's device or recovery process. Designs should minimise disclosed attributes, limit retention and avoid persistent identifiers that enable tracking across unrelated services. Any intermediary should be assessed for what it sees, stores, and can infer.

Revocation and recovery deserve equal attention to initial verification. Participants must be able to respond when credentials are lost, compromised, or withdrawn, and to communicate relevant status changes reliably. Services also need tested procedures for outages, interrupted connectivity, and compromised issuers. **An apparently secure design that leaves legitimate users stranded during a disruption has not met its purpose.**

Make inclusion and accountability conditions of participation

The people who could benefit most may lack current documents, smartphones, reliable connectivity or the ability to navigate complex appeals. Verification should therefore include proportionate alternatives and assisted channels appropriate to the service and applicable law. Essential rights and services should not depend on possessing a credential designed for border control. Providers should measure rejection, abandonment and recovery alongside speed, cost and fraud.

Purpose limits must be enforceable. Information collected to help someone access a service should not quietly become a resource for unrelated surveillance. Proposed data sharing needs a lawful basis, defined recipients, necessary attributes and clear retention rules. Where consent is relied upon, it must be meaningful; it cannot substitute for safeguards or cure an otherwise unlawful use. People need understandable notice and accessible routes to correction and review.

Liability must be agreed before institutions rely on one another's assertions. The issuer, intermediary and receiving institution should know their duties when information is inaccurate or a control fails. Oversight should be able to inspect evidence, investigate complaints and require corrective action. A verified identity must never be treated as proof of wrongdoing, and any adverse vetting result requires an appropriate process for challenge.

Turn interoperability into accountable practice

The first implementation decisions should concern purpose, partners and authority. Select a small number of services, map the legal and regulatory requirements, and agree which institution is authoritative for each attribute. Then define assurance equivalence, data-sharing limits, liability, security requirements and recovery arrangements. **Technical architecture should implement these decisions, rather than determine them by default.**

Identity authorities, central banks, financial intelligence units, data-protection regulators, immigration bodies, justice institutions, service providers and civil society all have relevant responsibilities. Their involvement should follow the chosen use case, with named owners for unresolved questions. Pilot

results should report benefits and failures honestly, including who remains excluded and whether corrective measures work. Expansion should depend on those results and continued compliance with participation requirements.

The Digital Trust Futures Foundation can contribute through independent assurance, cross-sector dialogue and open evaluation methods. Its role should be to test security and trust claims, make evidence usable to decision-makers, and help institutions address identified gaps. Published conflict policies, transparent methods, and separation from commercial interests are essential to that role. Cross-border identity becomes valuable when people can use it safely, institutions can justify their reliance, and failures can be corrected without stripping people of access or dignity.

Selected references

- FATF — Guidance on Digital Identity (2020).
- UNCITRAL — Model Law on the Use and Cross-border Recognition of Identity Management and Trust Services (2022).
- ICAO — Doc 9303, Machine Readable Travel Documents.
- World Health Organization — Global Digital Health Certification Network.

About the author

Godfrey Kutumela (He/Him)

CISSP (MSc Information Security), CCSP, CSSLP, TOGAF, ISO 27001 LA, MDP

Executive Lead and Digital Trust Practitioner, Digital Trust Futures Foundation

Godfrey Kutumela is a globally recognised cybersecurity practitioner with over 26 years of experience shaping secure digital ecosystems across fintech, identity and public infrastructure environments. He operates at the intersection of Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI), Digital Public Goods (DPGs) and national-scale platforms, bringing deep expertise in securing systems where the impact of failure is measured at the population level rather than the enterprise level.

- Trusted advisor to governments, foundations and ecosystem builders delivering secure-by-design DPI across Africa, Latin America and global markets.
- Core contributor to large-scale platforms including Mowali (mobile money interoperability infrastructure), Mojaloop (interoperable faster payments), MOSIP (digital identity) and Tazama (fraud systems).
- Designs and embeds independent, risk-based security practices across payment systems, identity frameworks and cross-border financial infrastructure.
- Works across policy, architecture and implementation layers, translating global standards into deployable security controls.

- Contributor to the Digital Public Goods Alliance (DPGA) Privacy Expert Group, shaping global privacy and security indicators.
- Active in open-source security, DevSecOps integration and supply chain assurance for reusable digital platforms.
- Delivered independent security reviews, penetration testing and architecture governance across critical DPI implementations.

His leadership philosophy in the DPI ecosystem is clear: security forms the foundation upon which safety and trust are built. Safety is what citizens experience in practice, and trust is the legitimacy that sustains adoption; once lost, it is difficult to restore.

About Digital Trust Futures Foundation

Digital Trust Futures Foundation is an independent, non-profit public-benefit organisation strengthening the safety, security, rights, inclusion and trustworthiness of digital public infrastructure (DPI), digital public goods (DPGs), open-source technology and AI-enabled public services. Its work is grounded in the recognition that DPI has become critical national infrastructure operating in a persistent threat environment, requiring independent, ecosystem-level assurance that goes beyond traditional approaches.

The Foundation operates outside vendor, implementer and platform incentives. It combines evidence-based cybersecurity, safety and AI-governance assurance with human-rights and child-protection expertise, and releases its tools, research and frameworks as reusable public goods rather than proprietary products — so that the value of a single engagement extends to every government, maintainer and community facing the same risk.

Digital Trust Futures Foundation NPC is registered as a non-profit company in South Africa and works across Africa and the wider Global South, with emphasis on countries and communities adopting DPI under capacity and assurance constraints.

Digital Trust Futures Foundation | Safe infrastructure. Trusted technology. Inclusive digital futures.
info@digitaltrustfuturesfoundation.org | digitaltrustfuturesfoundation.org | +27 83 680 3427

Published as a public good. This paper may be shared and quoted with attribution to Digital Trust Futures Foundation NPC. It is provided for general information and does not constitute a certification, assurance opinion or endorsement of any system, product or jurisdiction.